Xavier Dolan

Hello everyone, this is Hugo, and you're listening to episode seventeen of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:13] Welcome to this new episode. I hope you're enjoying the final weeks of summer, if it's summer where you are, and perhaps your last weeks of holiday too. Perhaps you're listening on the beach. If so, watch out for sunburn. "Sunburn" is when we spend too long in the sun and our skin begins burning and turning completely red. So if you're on the beach listening, remember sunscreen!

[00:01:00] Today, we won't discuss beaches and the sea, but cinema, particularly a very talented young director. I wanted to begin with a quotation. A quotation is reporting something someone else said. For example, after the president gives a speech, journalists can quote it. Or if there's a book you like, particularly a passage, you can quote that passage. Then you're making a quotation.

[00:02:00] The quotation I wanted to share comes from a play written in the seventeenth century by French playwright Pierre Corneille. It says, "Worth does not wait upon the number of years." Do you understand what that means? It means talent doesn't depend on age. You can be very talented even when very young. Conversely, if you have no talent, time won't change that. You can train and practise, but without talent for something, there's little chance it will come with age.

[00:03:13] Today's subject is precisely a very talented young man, particularly talented at directing films. He's a director, producer and actor from Canada, more precisely Montreal. He's so talented he directed his first film at only nineteen, which is quite exceptional. A nineteen-year-old director isn't something you see every day!

[00:04:03] Today, he's a little older, twenty-eight, so he began making films nearly ten years ago. During this short career, he's already won many awards, notably at Cannes. He's very popular in France and Canada, his native country.

[00:04:35] Perhaps you've guessed who I mean. Perhaps you've even seen some of his films. It's Xavier Dolan. Today, I'll discuss his career and personality, and of course his films. If you've never seen any, I hope this makes you want to watch some.

[00:05:05] OK, are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:05:17] Xavier Dolan was born on 20 March 1989 in Montreal, Quebec. We were born the same year, because I too was born in 1989. In other words, we're the same age. Unfortunately, I haven't had the same career. Xavier's father was of Egyptian origin and emigrated to Canada when young. He became a fairly popular actor and singer in Quebec. You may know Quebec is a Canadian region, where French is the official language. Since his father was already in show business, Xavier Dolan began appearing in television advertisements very young. Advertisements are announcements made by companies to sell products or services. We see them on television, at the cinema, hear them on radio, and receive them daily in our email inboxes. At four, Dolan made his television debut acting in advertisements for pharmacies. After these first advertisements, he began acting in Quebec films while still a child.

[00:07:18] At eight, young Xavier Dolan sent a letter to his favourite actor, an American you probably know, Leonardo DiCaprio. Quite amusingly, a French magazine recently found and published it. I'll read it so you can get an idea of young Xavier's character.

[00:07:54] "Hello Leonardo, my name is Xavier Dolan. I go to school, and love school. I'm eight. On 20 March, I'll be nine. I'm one of your fans. I've seen Titanic five times. You act very well. You're a great actor and I admire you. I'm an actor too. I've appeared in some advertisements for a very famous pharmacy chain and had good roles in four French-language films. I'd like to act in one of your films one day. I know you'll come to Montreal one day. Montreal is a very popular filming location. Last year, one hundred American films were shot here. I'll try to meet you then. When you come to Montreal to shoot a film, be sure I'll come to auditions in case you need a young boy in the cast."

[00:09:08] Already in this letter, we see that although he's young, eight when writing it, Xavier Dolan knows the film industry very well and is very determined. "Being determined" means knowing what you want and doing everything to achieve it. Then, he was mainly interested in acting, not yet wanting to direct. Yet directing would make him famous. Later, after high school, he studied arts and literature with a cinema specialisation, but quickly abandoned his studies. He felt university offered insufficient freedom, too many restrictions, and prevented him expressing his talent. So he left quite quickly.

[00:10:25] His ambition was still an acting career. Unfortunately, no roles were offered. So he decided to direct his own film and play its lead role. We understand Dolan is self-taught. A self-taught person learns alone, without a teacher. Dolan learned directing by himself, watching many films and drawing inspiration from what he saw.

[00:11:18] In 2008, aged nineteen, Dolan directed his first film himself and produced it through public funding. Canada has various institutions helping artists, particularly directors, produce their work. Dolan benefited from this assistance to make his first film.

[00:11:54] Its title is I Killed My Mother. Perhaps you imagine a horror film or psychological thriller because the title is rather dark. Actually, it isn't really horror, but a film about a mother-son relationship. It tells the story of sixteen-year-old Hubert, whose relationship with his mother is very difficult. He detests her: her tastes, clothes, way of being, absolutely everything. Unfortunately, he lives alone with her because his father abandoned them, left. Hubert and his mother spend their days arguing, shouting and insulting each other. It's quite violent, not necessarily physically, but verbally. Hubert's biggest problem is hiding his homosexuality because he thinks his mother couldn't accept it.

[00:13:29] The film is strongly autobiographical, meaning Dolan drew heavily on his own life for the screenplay. He wrote it at sixteen, the same age as Hubert. And, as you've guessed, Dolan himself plays the lead, Hubert.

[00:14:01] This first film was shown at a festival alongside Cannes, called the Directors' Fortnight. It's mainly for independent, small-budget films, and his film greatly impressed critics. It received three awards there. Media began taking interest in this little genius, already calling him a "child prodigy". Some critics wondered how a director of only twenty could show such maturity and mastery, especially in his first film. With I Killed My Mother's release, Dolan began attracting media attention.

[00:15:15] The film was released in France and Canada but didn't attract a large audience. It remained fairly independent. Afterwards, Dolan released a new film almost yearly. Like Woody Allen, he directs a new film every year. He has a reputation as a workaholic, someone working enormously, with a form of addiction to work. Reading his interviews, we realise he spends his life working, doing projects, thinking about screenplays. It's an obsession. He has many films in mind, so releases one almost every year. People working with him say his ideas are very precise. He knows exactly what he wants and gives actors and actresses detailed instructions. Sometimes he asks them to deliver a line ten or twelve different ways. Some actors find working with him interesting, but it can also be complicated because he's very demanding. At the same time, seeing such maturity in so young a director is quite surprising.

[00:17:27] Xavier Dolan's second film, Heartbeats, was released in 2010.

[00:17:36] It concerns a friendship between a young man and woman that becomes a love triangle when another young man arrives. The two friends compete to seduce him. Shot in Montreal, it's aesthetically interesting and has a wonderful soundtrack. A soundtrack is the music used in a film.

[00:18:29] His third film, Laurence Anyways, came out two years later, in 2012. Set in the nineties, it concerns a couple whose husband decides to become a woman, to change sex. It shows the obstacles the couple must overcome, problems with those around them and others' perceptions, and how they confront them.

[00:19:15] A year later, in 2013, came Tom at the Farm. Unlike the first three, it's a thriller somewhat in Hitchcock's style. You probably know the famous American [correction: British] director Alfred Hitchcock. It's a psychological thriller involving a young gay man and his deceased boyfriend's brother. Tom visits his late boyfriend's family and meets the brother for the first time. His outlook is completely different from Tom's. Gradually, Tom becomes a prisoner on this farm and must face the brother's psychological pressure. It's a very tense, interesting film, highly appreciated by critics.

[00:20:48] But the film that really made Dolan famous came out in 2014: Mommy. It's his best-known, most successful film. For the first time, it was presented at Cannes and won the Jury Prize. Again, it concerns a mother-son relationship, a subject Dolan finds fascinating and explores differently in different films. This time, the son has psychological disorders. He's often violent in words and actions. His mother struggles to care for Steve, the child's name. She's alone because her husband died and doesn't know how to manage the violence of a son she loves immensely but for whom she can't find a solution. The film explores their relationship through love, violence, tenderness and insults. It shows a very fragile balance they find with a new neighbour's help, but which unfortunately won't last.

[00:22:41] Audiences and critics loved this film because it conveys so much emotion. Watching it is extremely interesting, and I think afterwards we're no longer exactly the same person. For me, that shows it's a great film. It's beautiful and deeply moving and, as I said, Dolan's first real popular success. If you've never seen his films, start with this one. Watch Mommy first. Try finding French subtitles because Quebec French isn't always easy to understand. When Quebec films are released in French cinemas, they often have subtitles, because even French people find them quite difficult to understand.

[00:23:58] His latest film, It's Only the End of the World, came out in 2016. It's his first made in France with very famous French actors and actresses, including Marion Cotillard, Vincent Cassel and Léa Seydoux. Adapted from a play, it concerns a writer returning to his family in his native village after twelve years away. He returns to tell them he'll soon die. This reunion, meaning seeing someone absent for a long time, revives memories but also creates family tensions. I suggest listening to a scene at the lunch table with the different family members.

[00:25:22] "What? The old house?
Yes.
What?
Well, he wants to see the old house again. I don't mind. I can drive you if you want.
But why do you want to go back there? Are you stupid or what?
He isn't stupid, listen, if he wants to. Are you… are you stupid, perhaps?
And are you an idiot?
And why, Louis, seriously? Why go back there? Did you forget something in your room?
No, I… I don't know… just because. I'm curious to know… well, to see the place again, see how it's evolved, how time has changed it, battered it."

[00:26:08] You see, this scene reveals a communication problem. On one side is Louis, the writer returning to his family, but almost a stranger. They don't understand him, and he doesn't understand them either. He can't communicate openly. There's a form of incomprehension. What's very interesting is that we can all recognise familiar things, reminders of our own families. Communication problems within families are quite universal, I think. The film shows how they develop and how hard solving them is.

[00:27:23] This too is a film I recommend, and it will also be good practice for improving your French comprehension.

[00:27:43] This year, Dolan is due to release his first English-language film. We can wonder whether he'll become famous outside French-language cinema. Will he establish himself among the great directors of English-language cinema?

[00:28:11] In any case, successful or not, at twenty-eight Dolan has already accomplished more than many older directors. He already has a phenomenal career and many awards for beautiful films. I hope he keeps his energy and explores other subjects in future films.

[00:28:54] That's the end of this podcast. Thank you very much for listening. I hope you found it interesting and, above all, want to watch Dolan's films. Perhaps you're already fans. If so, I'd like to know your favourite film and why. If you've seen his films, write and tell me your favourite and which you'd recommend to others.

[00:29:40] As usual, if you enjoy this podcast and want to help, you can leave a rating on iTunes if you listen there, or on the other applications you use. That lets me reach more and more listeners and help more and more people.

[00:30:11] Of course, there'll be a new podcast next week, this time about the uberisation of the economy. A slightly different subject, but one I think may interest you. I hope you'll join me next week. Thank you, and see you soon!